down the caste hierarchy). In this, the BJP emulated the SP government that preceded it. It issued an order for reclassifying these castes as SCs on the grounds that they had missed out on the benefits of reservation because more dominant castes had cornered the lion's share of these. This reclassification, issued in June 2019, was stayed three months later by the Supreme Court. Still, the political point was made.[29] The castes that the BJP pushed for reclassifying included Nishad, Bind, Mallah, Kewat, Kashyap, Bhar, Dhivar, Batham, Machua, Prajapati, Rajbhar, Kahar, Pottar, Dhimar, Manjhi, Tuhaha and Gaur.[30]

This followed a hugely significant earlier move by Yogi Adityanath's government as soon as it came to power in 2017 when it began talking about a proposed caste-wise division, and quotas within the 27 per cent government jobs and education seats reserved for OBCs in UP. Using the same argument, that these castes had been left out in practice by dominant OBC castes, a four-member social-justice committee specially set up by Yogi Adityanath's government presented a report in December 2018. It suggested a further carving out and streamlining of OBC reservation quotas into three broad categories. Headed by Justice Raghvendra Kumar, the committee suggested that the most prosperous of the OBC castes (Yadavs, Kurmis, Chaurasias, Patels) should only get 7 per cent of the reservation seats and be reclassified as Backward Castes. It further recommended that a second category—Most Backward Classes (including Gujjars, Lodhs, Kushwahas, Shakyas, Telis, Sahus, Sainis, Malis and Nishads)—should get 11 per cent of the pie. Finally, that a third category—Most Backward Castes (including Ghosis, Qureshis among Muslims, Rajbhars, Binds and Nishads)—should get 9 per cent reservation.[31] At the time of writing, this has not yet been implemented, but the BJP's political messaging on rejigging caste benefits was clear. At its heart was a targeted political strategy to remap the OBC vote and draw in the castes that had felt subsumed by Yadav dominance.

Sharing the Spoils of Power: The BJP's New OBC Tilt